

Rating Area 4: Southwest / Pittsburgh Metro

Hub: Pittsburgh | Counties: Allegheny, Armstrong, Beaver, Butler, Fayette, Greene, Indiana, Lawrence, Washington, Westmoreland

21.5% PID-approved avg. individual rate hike	102% avg. net premium increase, 2026	443,024 PA enrollees as of June 1, 2026	160,000+ cumulative PA terminations
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THE STATEWIDE PICTURE

The federal enhanced premium tax credits expired December 31, 2025, and Congress has not restored them; combined with the Pennsylvania Insurance Department's (PID) approved 21.5% average individual-market rate increase, Pennie reports the average net premium for the affected population rose 102% for 2026 (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025; Pennie, 2026a). Statewide, 85,000 people dropped Pennie coverage during Open Enrollment; as of June 1, 2026, cumulative cancellations exceed 160,000 and total enrollment stands at 443,024 (Pennie, 2026a, 2026b). Pennsylvania's own relief program, the Act 54 state subsidy, remains unfunded as the state budget missed its June 30, 2026 deadline for the fifth year running (Spotlight PA, 2026).

CARRIERS & RATES IN THIS AREA

Pennsylvania's second-largest market is dominated by two vertically integrated systems: Highmark (approved 17.7%) and UPMC's health plans, both of which pair insurance with direct ownership of hospitals and physician groups (Pennsylvania Insurance Department, 2025; WITF, 2025). UPMC's plans have carried some of the state's larger approved increases this cycle as insurers cited a sicker-than-projected risk pool — confirm your specific plan's 2026 rate directly with PID's posted rate filings rather than a prior-year figure.

VERTICAL INTEGRATION CUTS BOTH WAYS

Being insured and treated by the same system can mean smoother referrals — but it also means your plan choice is effectively a hospital-network choice. Before enrolling, confirm your specific physicians are in the plan's *current* tier, not just "in-network" broadly; tiered cost-sharing has expanded across both major systems for 2026.

YOUR CONSUMER PROTECTIONS

If a directory error sends you out-of-network: 28 Pa. Code § 9.725 caps your liability at in-network cost-sharing, and Act 252 of 2023 presumes an undisclosed out-of-network balance bill illegal. The federal IDR process (45 C.F.R. § 149.510) is a *provider-vs-plan* tool only — you cannot file one yourself; use the protections above instead.

Enroll / compare plans: pennie.com or 1-844-844-8040	File a complaint: pa.gov/consumer or 1-866-722-6675
Free legal help: phlp.org or 1-800-274-3258	Medicare counseling: PA MEDI 1-800-783-7067

SOURCES (APA)

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- WITF. (2025, Oct. 17). *Health insurance rates... double-digit increase in 2026*. witf.org